Logic of Domestic Politics

Lectures: Mon & Wed at 1:25 pm to 2:40 pm
Location: Gross Hall 111
Instructor: Jiawei Fu (jiawei.fu@duke.edu)
Office Hour: [link], Gross Hall 294A or online

Course Description

Why do political candidates sometimes adopt similar policy positions? How do interest groups influence public policy? Why do legislatures delegate authority to bureaucrats? What makes political leaders accountable to citizens? Why do some authoritarian regimes survive while others collapse?

This course introduces students to the formal analysis of domestic politics. We examine how political actors make strategic decisions and how political institutions shape political outcomes. Topics include electoral competition, lobbying and campaign finance, legislative bargaining, bureaucracy, delegation, coalition formation, political agency, nondemocratic institutions, and regime change.

For students primarily interested in understanding real-world politics, this course offers a systematic framework for analyzing political behavior and institutions. Students will learn to identify the incentives and strategic interactions underlying political events, understand why political actors make particular decisions, and critically evaluate competing explanations of political outcomes. These analytical skills will help students better understand contemporary political developments and assess political arguments and policy debates.

For students interested in conducting academic research, this course provides the foundational skills needed to develop their own formal theoretical models, derive testable hypotheses, use empirical data to evaluate theoretical predictions, and ultimately write a complete research paper.

Requirements and Grading

Participation and engagement (10%): Students are expected to attend class regularly, ask questions, and participate constructively in discussions and model-solving activities.

Four Short Problem Sets (50%): Four short problem sets will reinforce the main concepts and analytical techniques covered in class. Questions will focus on solving simple games, explaining equilibrium outcomes, interpreting theoretical results, and applying models to political examples.

Final Project (40%): Students will prepare a short memo of approximately 3–4 pages that develops an original theoretical research idea. The memo should:

- Identify a political phenomenon or research question.
- Explain a potential strategic mechanism.
- Describe the relevant actors, their choices, incentives, and interactions.
- Present a simple formal model or a sufficiently precise outline of one.
- Discuss possible theoretical predictions and how they might be evaluated empirically.

Course Materials

- Primary textbook: Gehlbach, Scott. 2021. Formal Models of Domestic Politics. 2nd edition. Cambridge University Press.

  This book provides the main theoretical framework and supplies most of the models covered in the course.

- Supplementary textbook: Bueno de Mesquita, Ethan. 2016. Political Economy for Public Policy. Princeton University Press.

Tentative Course Schedule

Week	Topics and Central Questions	Readings
1	**Introduction: The Logic of Politics.** Why use formal models? Preferences, institutions, strategic interaction, mechanisms, and testable predictions.	Gehlbach, Preface; Bueno de Mesquita, Introduction.
2	**Game Theory I: Strategic-Form Games.** Players, actions, strategies, payoffs, best responses, dominant strategies, and Nash equilibrium.	Bueno de Mesquita, Appendix A; lecture notes.
3	**Game Theory II: Sequential Games.** Game trees, backward induction, subgame-perfect equilibrium, commitment, and credibility.	Bueno de Mesquita, Appendix B; lecture notes.
4	**Electoral Competition under Certainty.** Spatial voting, the median voter theorem, and policy convergence. When do candidates adopt similar policies?	Gehlbach, Chapter 1.
5	**Electoral Competition under Uncertainty.** Probabilistic voting, candidate motivations, valence, and policy divergence. Why do candidates sometimes adopt different policies?	Gehlbach, Chapter 2.
6	**Campaign Finance and Political Competition.** Campaign contributions, advertising, and electoral incentives. How does money influence elections?	Gehlbach, Chapter 3 (selected sections).
7	**Lobbying and Special Interests.** Organized interests, lobbying competition, and policy influence. Why do some groups have more influence than others?	Gehlbach, Chapter 3 (selected sections).
8	**Veto Players and Policy Stability.** Status quo policies, institutional constraints, and the difficulty of policy change. *Midterm examination.*	Gehlbach, Chapter 4 (selected sections).
9	**Legislative Bargaining and Agenda Setting.** Proposal power, voting rules, bargaining, and legislative outcomes. Who benefits from controlling the agenda?	Gehlbach, Chapter 4 (selected sections).
10	**Delegation and Bureaucracy.** Principal-agent relationships, bureaucratic discretion, information asymmetry, and institutional design. Why delegate authority?	Gehlbach, Chapter 5.

Week	Topics and Central Questions	Readings
11	**Coalitions and Government Formation.** Coalition bargaining, minimum winning coalitions, and the distribution of political power. Why do some coalitions form rather than others?	Gehlbach, Chapter 6.
12	**Political Agency and Accountability.** Elections as mechanisms of selection and discipline, moral hazard, and voter information. When can voters hold politicians accountable?	Gehlbach, Chapter 7.
13	**Nondemocratic Institutions.** Authoritarian rulers, elites, institutions, information, and repression. Why do dictators establish political institutions?	Gehlbach, Chapter 8.
14	**Regime Change and Democratization.** Collective action, revolutionary threats, political transitions, and institutional change. Why do regimes collapse or democratize?	Gehlbach, Chapter 9.
15	**From Political Models to Research.** Comparing theoretical explanations, linking predictions to evidence, recognizing limitations, and developing original models. Course synthesis and research memo workshop.	Selected review and application materials.

Note: The schedule is tentative and may be adjusted according to the pace of the class and the academic calendar. Specific readings and supplementary materials will be announced in advance.